



MODULE 9

Mental health and warning signs

Do you recognize the difference between an athlete who is struggling and one who is in mental danger?

CORE THEORY

Mental health problems are more common in athletes than non-athletes (Gouttebarga et al., 2019). Coaches are often the first adults to pick up signals, before parents or school. The Duty of Care obligation requires coaches to actively ensure the wellbeing of their athletes. Burnout in youth (Raedeke, 1997) has three dimensions: emotional exhaustion, depersonalization (sport feels meaningless), and reduced sense of competence. Early recognition is life-changing.

Source: Gouttebarga et al. (2019) · Raedeke (1997) · Rice et al. (2016) · UK Sport Duty of Care (2017)

"Take care of the person behind the athlete. The performances will follow."

Áine O'Connor, British Athletics

"When a coach asks how someone is doing and truly listens to the answer, that can change a life."

Michael Phelps

SELF-REFLECTION

- 1 What signals of mental overload do you recognize in athletes? Make a concrete list of 5 signs.
- 2 How do you ask players how they are really doing, in a way that makes them feel safe to answer honestly?
- 3 What do you do when you suspect a player is not doing well mentally? Do you have a protocol?
- 4 Where are the limits of your role as a coach? When do you refer on, and to whom?
- 5 How do you protect your own mental health as a coach? What do you do for self-care?

NOTES

**BOOKS**

- **Why Has Nobody Told Me This Before?**
Dr. Julie Smith
Why: A psychiatrist explains mental health tools for everyone. Helps coaches understand what their players are going through.
- **The Brave Athlete**
Simon Marshall & Lesley Paterson
Why: The neuroscience manual for athletes on anxiety, motivation, and self-criticism. Read as a coach to better understand your players.
- **Lost Connections**
Johann Hari
Why: Depression and anxiety are social, not only biochemical. Rewrites how you look at players who withdraw.

**VIDEO'S / TED TALKS**

- **Michael Phelps on Mental Health in Sport**
Michael Phelps (Realmindful)
[youtube.com/results?search_query=michael+phelps+mental+health+athlete](https://www.youtube.com/results?search_query=michael+phelps+mental+health+athlete)
The most successful Olympian ever on depression and the role of coaches. Powerful.
- **The Secret of Becoming Mentally Strong**
Amy Morin (TEDx)
[youtube.com/watch?v=TFbv757kup4](https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=TFbv757kup4)
Habits that undermine mental strength. Do you recognize these in your players, or yourself?

**PODCASTS**

- **The Mind Your Mental Health Podcast**
Mental health in youth sport
mindyourmentalhealth.ca
- **Finding Mastery**
Episode on athlete mental health and coach responsibility
findingmastery.com

⚡ ACTION THIS WEEK

Create a "signal card" for yourself: 5 behavioral changes that indicate a player is struggling. Also agree on who your contact person is (trusted person, school counselor) if you need to refer someone.

My action plan if I notice a player is struggling mentally:
